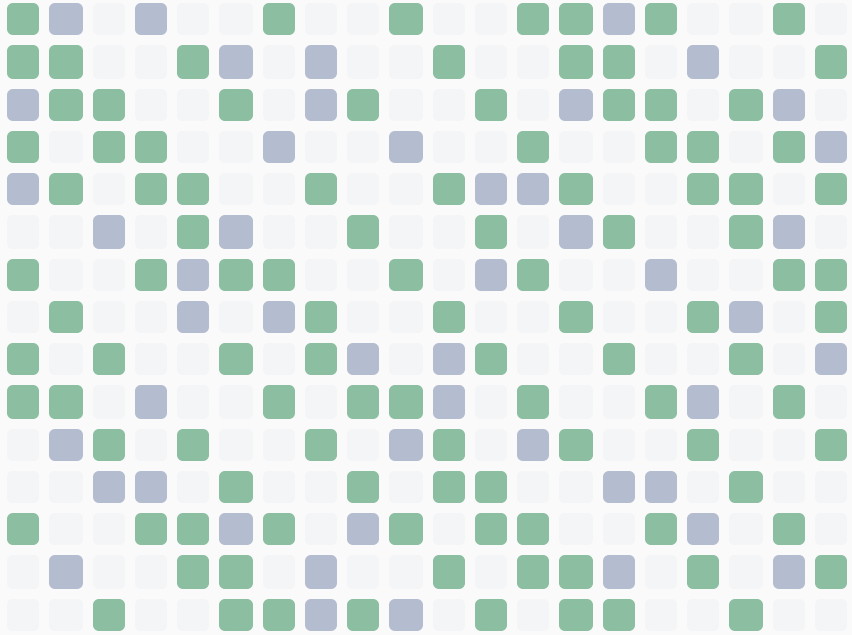
The Memory-Bandwidth Wall

A field guide to min-maxing LLM serving with vLLM

Your dashboard says busy. Your users say slow.

bandwidth ÷ bytes per token = tok/s



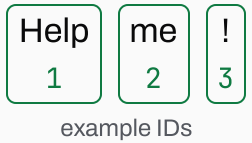
Marcel Wysocki · Senior Principal Architect · Red Hat Global Services

CONTAINERDAYS & AI CONTEXT SINGAPORE · 28 OCT 2026

Five stages of a request.

Tokenize

Prompt to token IDs (numbers).



example IDs

Prefill

Prompt tokens in parallel. Compute-heavy.


parallel

Write KV

Keys and values stored per token, per attention layer.



Decode

One token per step. Rereads weights and KV.



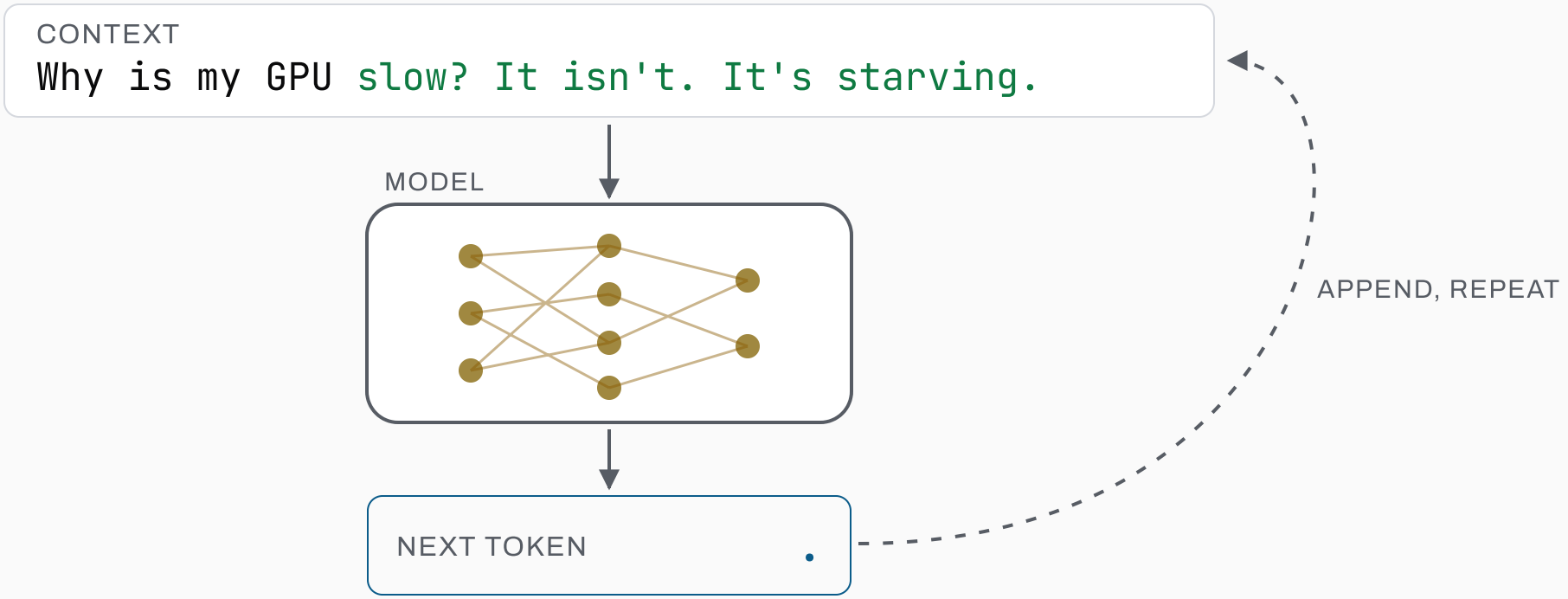
Stream

Tokens back to the user.

Here you go.

This talk is about the **three middle stages**.

Every new token goes around the loop again.



WEIGHTS · READ EVERY STEP

Qwen3.8-27B · bf16 (16-bit) · 55.6 GB checkpoint

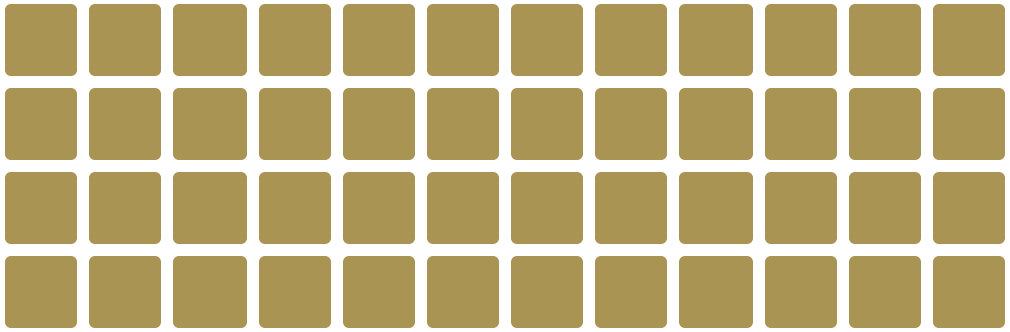
KV CACHE · GROWS EVERY STEP

12 tokens

Schematic. Qwen3.8-27B bf16 checkpoint: 55.6 GB; a decode step reads about 51 GB of it.

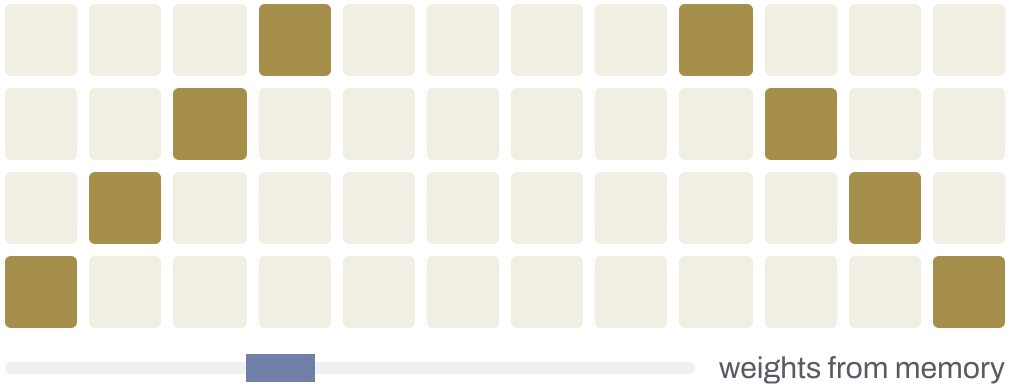
Long-prompt prefill is usually compute-bound. Small-batch decode is usually memory-bound.

Prefill



n tokens in one pass. Matrix units (tensor cores) saturated. Cost scales with **FLOPs** (math operations).

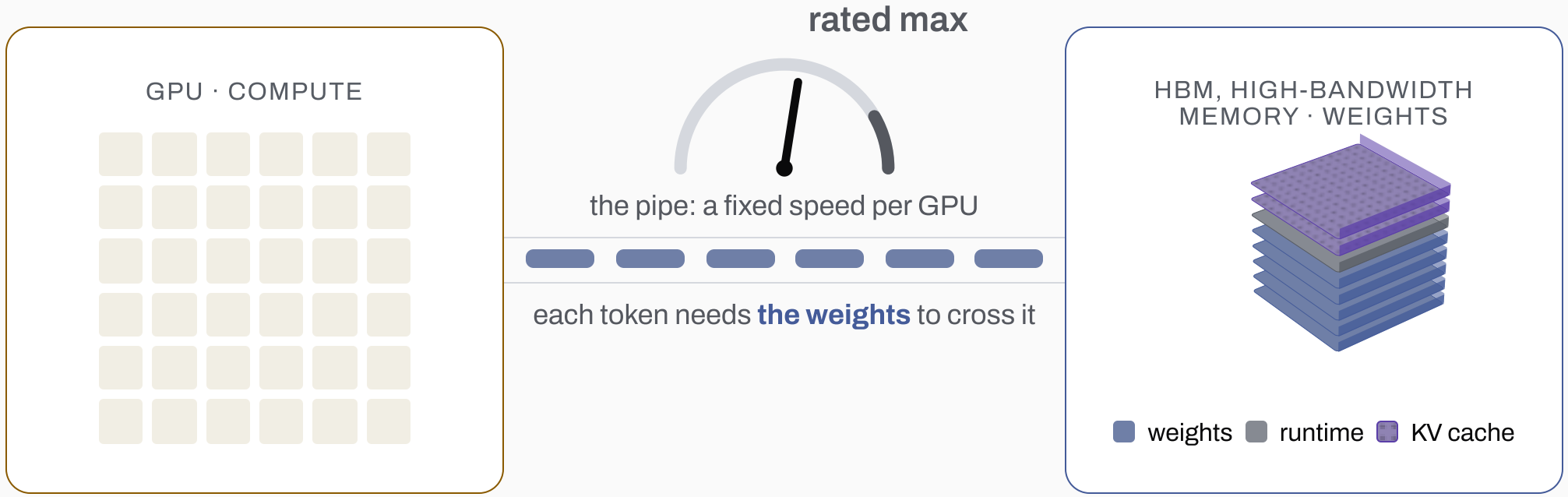
Decode



1 token per pass. Cores wait on memory. Cost scales with **bytes**.

Schematic.

Your GPU isn't slow. It's starving.



Tokens per second is pipe speed divided by bytes per token.

bandwidth ÷ bytes per token = tok/s

In vLLM: **measure decode tokens per second**, then compare it with the ceiling.

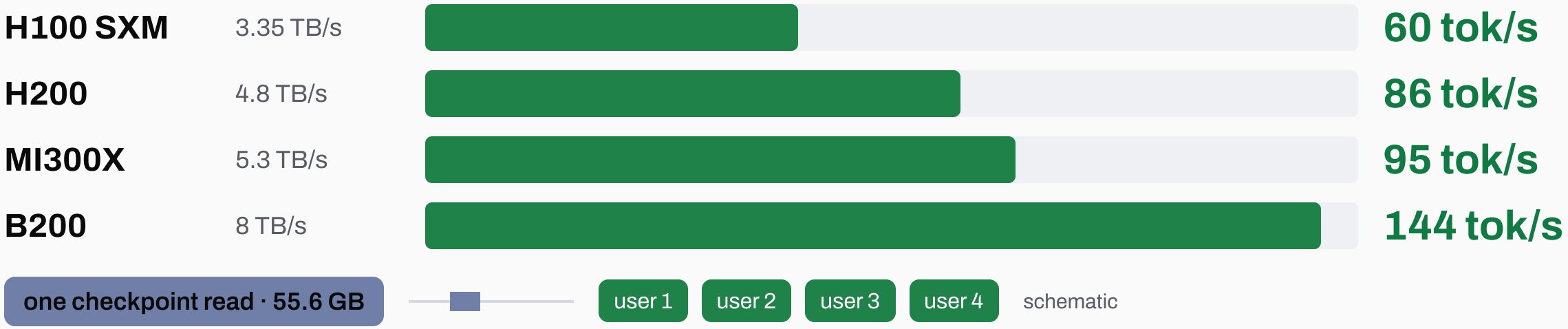
Schematic: one dense-model stream, short context, speculation off. The checkpoint is a first estimate of weight bytes read.

Divide before you tune.

Checkpoint-based estimate: how many times per second the pipe can deliver the stored file.

55.6 GB checkpoint | H100 SXM pipe · 3.35 TB/s | GPU | **60 tok/s**

`pipe speed ÷ 55.6 GB checkpoint (Qwen3.8-27B, bf16)`

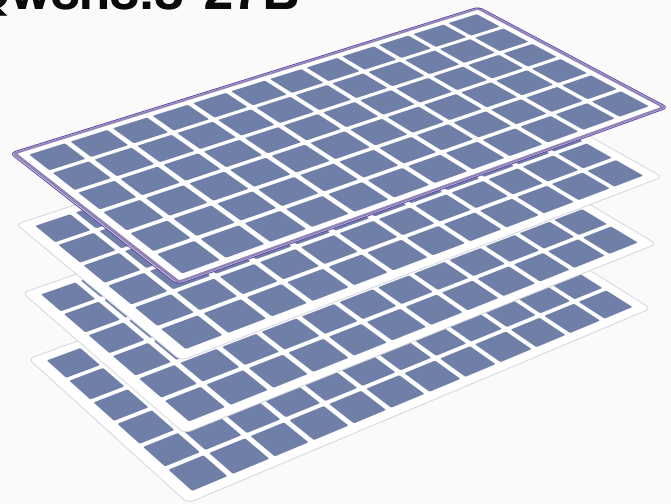


Batching: one read, more users get a token. It never shrinks the read.

Vendor HBM spec sheets ÷ the 55.6 GB checkpoint. Share row schematic.

Dense layers read all their weights.
Expert layers read the ones they pick.

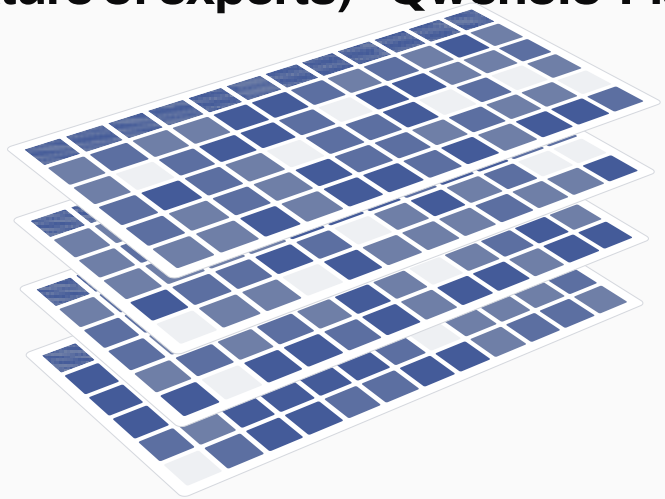
Dense · Qwen3.8-27B



weights attention layer, 1 in 4: writes the KV cache

51 GB decode weights per step · shared across the batch

MoE (mixture of experts) · Qwen3.8-Flash-Next



always read experts, shaded by the request that picked them

231 GB read per step at batch 128: 92% of 250 GB decode weights

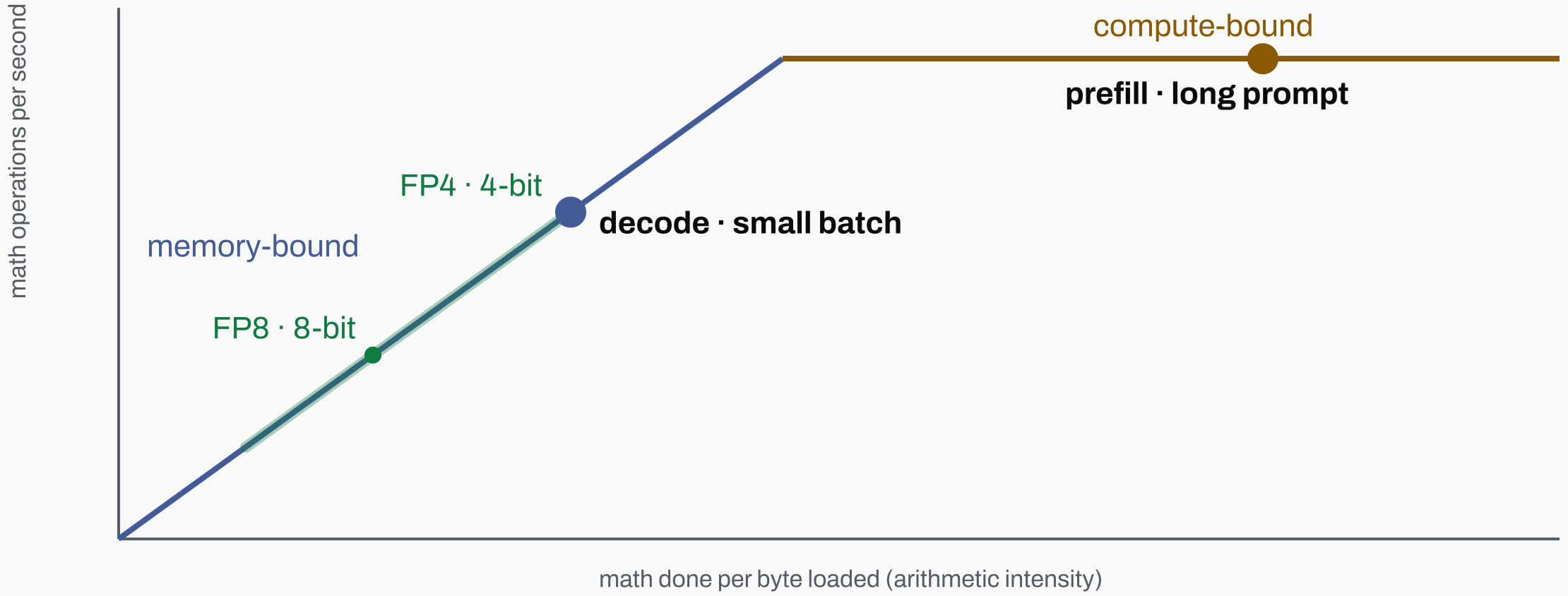
1 Size memory for **all** the weights.

2 Compute the one-user ceiling from the **active** bytes.

3 Under load, plan bandwidth for nearly all the weights.

Four layer planes, schematic. Qwen3.8-Flash-Next config.json: 512 routed experts, top-10, 1 shared. bf16 bytes per decode step: 13.3 GB at batch 1, 231 of 250.2 GB at batch 128, assuming uniform routing (arXiv:2511.02237).

Small-batch decode sits on the slope. Long-prompt prefill sits on the roof.



Schematic. Yuan et al. 2024, "LLM Inference Unveiled", arXiv:2402.16363.

MBU tells you whether overhead tuning can help.

THE MEMORY PIPE · SCHEMATIC



reads mostly back to back

MBU: **how full the pipe is.**

`one-user tok/s ÷ one-user ceiling`

High MBU

The pipe is likely the limit. Confirm in a profile before you stop tuning overhead. Fewer bytes still raise tok/s.

TRY

```
VLLM_WORKER_MULTIPROC_METHOD=spawn nsys profile \
  --trace-fork-before-exec=true --cuda-graph-trace=node \
  --capture-range=cudaProfilerApi --capture-range-end repeat \
  vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --profiler-config.profiler cuda
```

CHECK

```
vllm bench serve --backend vllm --model Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --dataset-name random \
  --random-input-len 1024 --random-output-len 512 --num-prompts 2 --max-concurrency 1 --profile
nsys stats report1.nsys-rep
```

Model bandwidth utilization (MBU), Databricks 2023. Short-context, one-user estimate; not a hardware-counter reading. No universal stop-tuning percentage.

Measure your MBU in five minutes.

```
# 1 · Fetch the index, not the weights
MODEL=Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B
REV=1d4bf0f2ff6012fd82039f2fa52739d0dd7c60c0
curl -fsSL "https://huggingface.co/$MODEL/resolve/"\
"$REV/model.safetensors.index.json" |
  jq '.metadata.total_size / 1e9'

# 55.56 GB: the whole checkpoint
# Text decode reads about 51.25 GB.
# Vision, MTP and most input embeddings
# aren't read at each text-decode step.
# Text-decode byte estimate: handout §1
```

```
# 2 · Warm server: qwen38 on port 18082
vllm bench serve --backend vllm --model qwen38 \
  --tokenizer Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --port 18082 \
  --dataset-name random --seed 1234 \
  --random-input-len 128 --random-output-len 128 \
  --max-concurrency 1 --num-prompts 4 \
  --num-warmups 1 --ignore-eos --temperature 0
```

```
# 3 · Use Mean TPOT, not aggregate output tok/s
ceiling = 273 GB/s ÷ 51.25 GB = 5.33 tok/s
measured = 1000 ÷ 222.5 ms = 4.49 tok/s
MBU = 4.49 ÷ 5.33 ≈ 84%
```

Spark · untuned baseline: **222.5 ms** TPOT (time per output token) ≈ **4.49 tok/s** ÷ 5.33 ≈ **84% MBU**.

DGX Spark · Qwen3.8-27B bf16 · vLLM 0.32.0 · 25 Oct 2026. Median: 3 × 16 saved coding prompts, 128 output tokens. Eager, prefix/chunking off. Weight estimate omits vision, MTP (multi-token prediction) layers, full input embeddings and KV/state traffic. 273 GB/s: NVIDIA. Warm-server diagnostic above; repeatable test: handout §2.

Weights and runtime come first. The KV cache gets the rest.



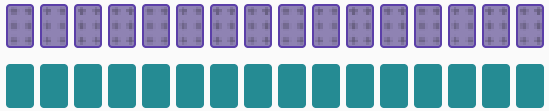
DGX SPARK EXAMPLE · SERVER BUDGET 85.2 GiB · Qwen3.8-27B bf16 · UTILIZATION 0.70

CONVERSATIONS · IDEAL PAYLOAD ESTIMATE **3** 128k context

Spark1 records: 121.6877 GiB system memory × chosen 0.70 − 51.7471 GiB checkpoint − 4 GiB assumed runtime ≈ 29.4 GiB. Divide by 64 KiB × context + 147 MiB state. Bar spans the selected 85.2 GiB server budget, to scale. Payload estimate; check startup capacity.

Do the KV math once instead of guessing.

Every token leaves a **key** and a **value**: two lists of numbers.



key · 256 numbers

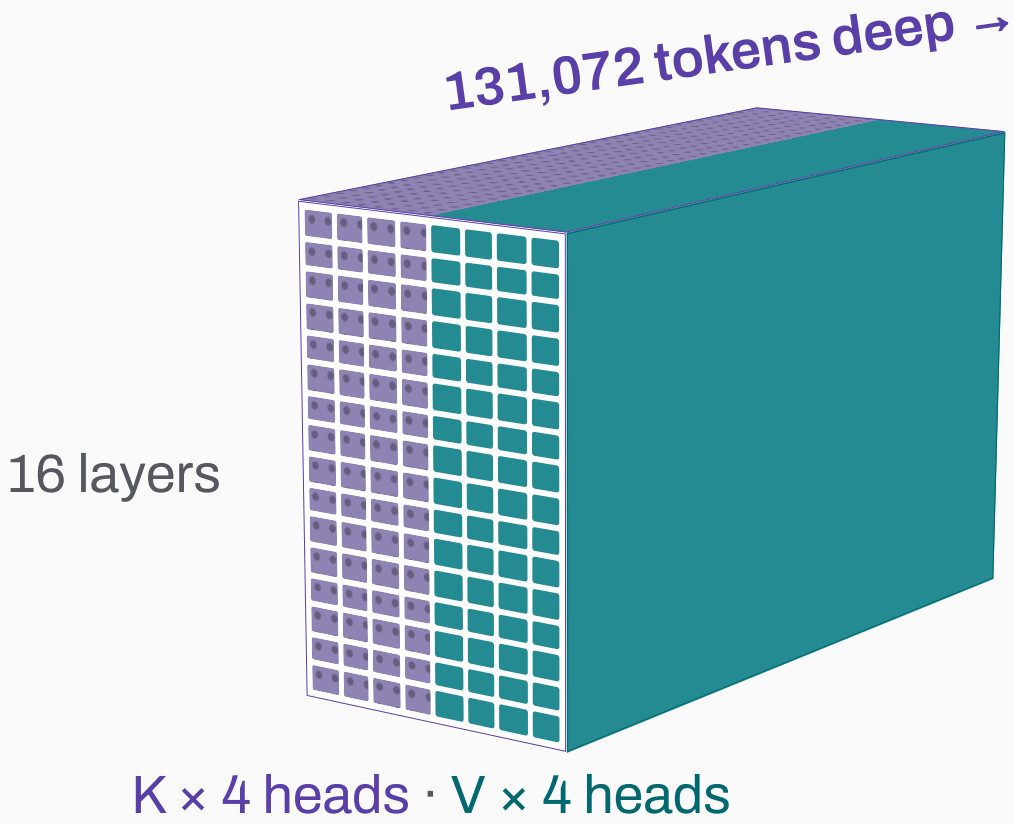
value · 256 numbers

× **16** attention layers × **4** KV heads · each list **256** numbers, **2** bytes apiece

= **64 KiB** per token: one slab

```
2 × 16 × 4 × 256 × 2 B = 65,536 B = 64 KiB
```

× 131,072 tokens = **8 GiB** for one 128k conversation



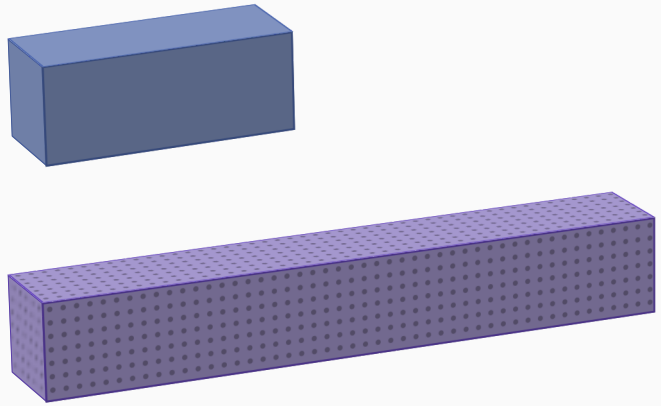
+ the other 48 layers (Gated DeltaNet): one fixed 147 MiB state.
Payload ≈ 8.1 GiB, before state copies and block padding.

Qwen3.8-27B config.json: 64 layers, 16 full attention (4 KV heads, head_dim 256), 48 Gated DeltaNet with 146.8 MiB fixed state per sequence (fp32 recurrent, bf16 convolution) (vLLM 0.31.0 mamba_utils.py). Strips schematic.

At long context, the KV cache outgrows the weights.

weights **51.7 GiB**
= 55.6 GB

KV · 16 users **130.3 GiB**



2.5× the weights

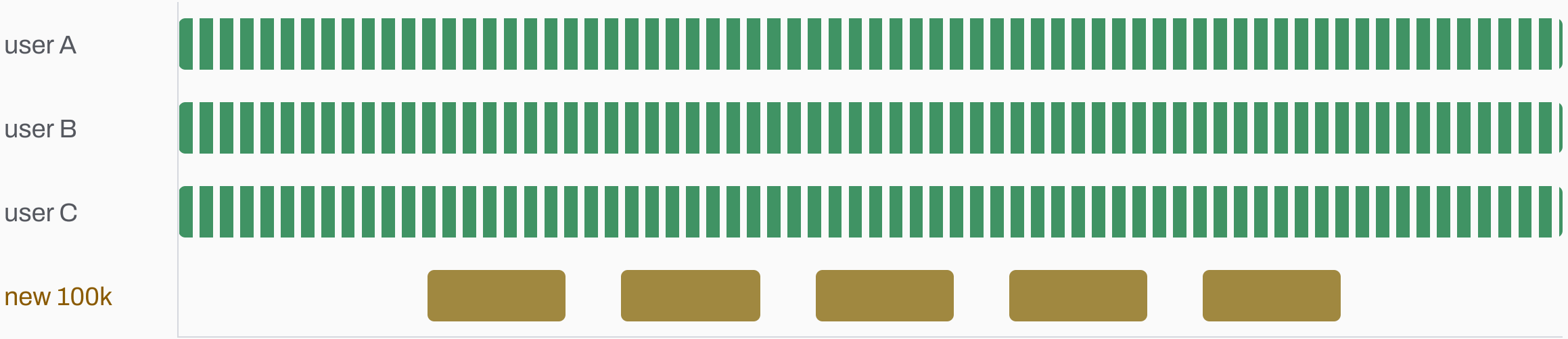
same front face for both: depth is bytes, drawn to scale

4k 32k **128k**

Qwen3.8-27B, 64 KiB per token. The weight footprint stays fixed. The KV doesn't.

Computed: 16 users × (64 KiB × tokens + 147 MiB state) = 6.3 / 34.3 / 130.3 GiB at 4k / 32k / 128k; weights 51.7 GiB (the 55.6 GB checkpoint). Depth to scale; front face schematic.

Unchunked, one 100k prompt stalls everyone else.



Chunked prefill: slices of the prompt, interleaved with everyone's decode.

```
TRY    --max-num-batched-tokens 2048 · 8192 · 16384 (scheduling-step token budget)
CHECK  P95 (95th percentile) vllm:inter_token_latency_seconds vs P95 TTFT (time to first token)
```

Timeline schematic. vLLM 0.32.0 serving defaults: chunked prefill on where supported; --max-num-batched-tokens = 8192 on Spark (GB10), H100/H200; 16384 on B200.

Four levers. Pull the one your traffic needs.

1

Reuse the prefix

skip prefill you already paid for

agents, RAG (retrieval-augmented generation), shared prompts

2

Fewer weight bytes

shrink the per-token read

high MBU, short context

3

Fewer KV bytes

shrink the context read

long context, many users

4

Speculative decoding

more tokens per weight read

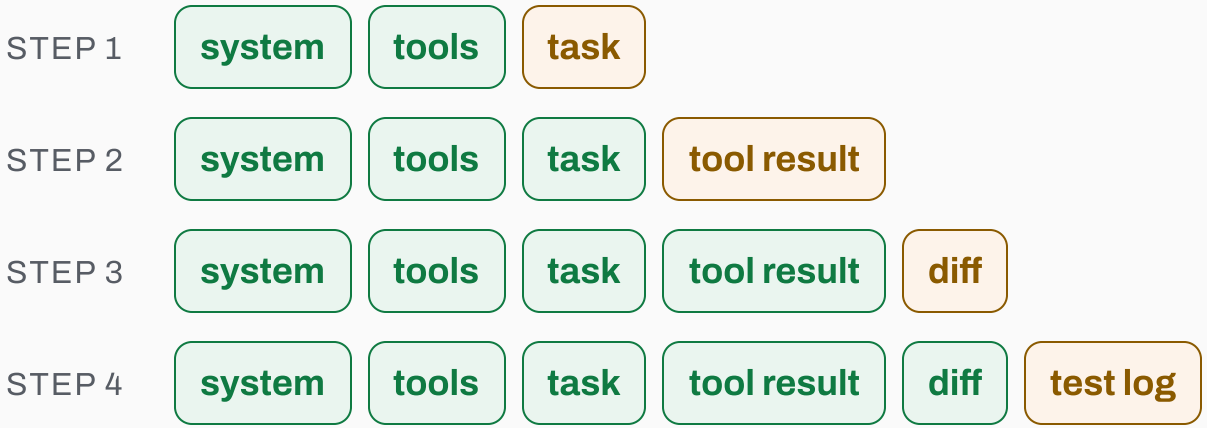
predictable output

skip repeated work

min the bytes

max the tokens per read

An agent resends the same prefix on every step.



0 repeated pieces recomputed

CACHE HIT: REUSED PREFIX

$0.022

per 1M cached input tokens

Developers with the same harness and tools can share the prefix.

```
TRY    on by default · compare with --no-enable-prefix-caching
CHECK  sum(rate(vllm:prefix_cache_hits_total[5m])) / sum(rate(vllm:prefix_cache_queries_total[5m]))
```

Turns schematic. Price: DeepSeek V4-Pro, off-peak, checked 25 Oct 2026. Share prefixes within an approved group; use different secret "cache_salt" values across required isolation boundaries (vLLM 0.31.0).

KV offload adds capacity and transfer latency.

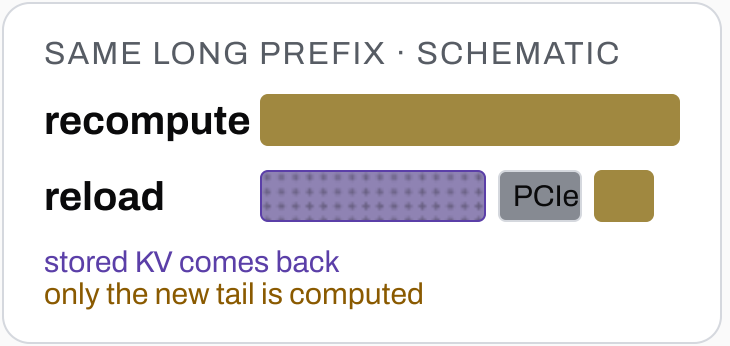
HBM ≈ 3–8 TB/s · tens to hundreds of GB

KV

CPU memory over PCIe 5 x16, the CPU-to-GPU link
≈ 64 GB/s each way

Local flash storage ≈ 7–14 GB/s per drive

Remote storage network-bound · measure reload latency



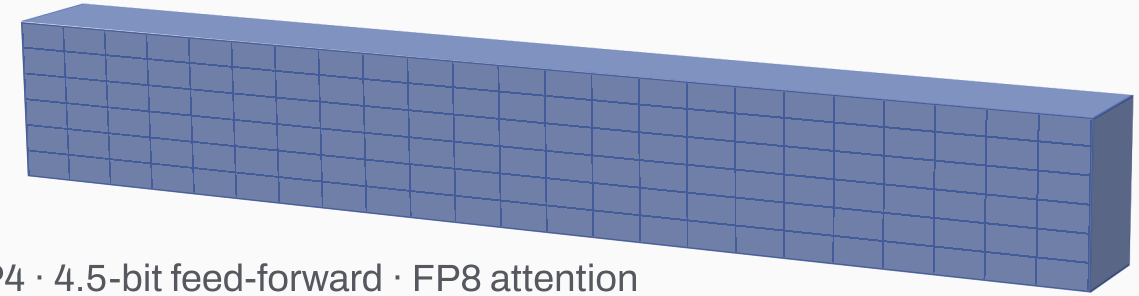
More capacity, with transfer time to pay. Reload only when the transfer beats the recompute: measure it.

```
TRY    LMCache multiprocess server · --mamba-cache-mode align · disk-reuse procedure: handout
CHECK  sum(rate(vllm:external_prefix_cache_hits_total[5m])) / sum(rate(vllm:external_prefix_cache_queries_total[5m]))
```

Discrete-GPU tiers, schematic; the Spark shares CPU/GPU memory, so its experiment uses disk without CPU retention. vLLM 0.31.0: CPU offload size is GiB summed across GPUs. Router-visible native offload needs "self_describing_kv_events" and KV event publishing, both off by default. Bandwidths: vendor specs, PCIe 5 x16, Gen4–Gen5 NVMe.

Weight quantization shrinks the weight read. The ceiling rises in proportion.

QWEN3.8-27B CHECKPOINT · SAME WEIGHTS, FEWER BYTES EACH · THICKNESS TO SCALE



NVFP4 · 4.5-bit feed-forward · FP8 attention

21.9 GB

ONE-USER CEILING · B200, 8 TB/s · ONE BOX = ONE TOKEN'S WEIGHTS



365 tok/s

NVFP4 runs W4A4 (4-bit weights, 4-bit activations: the values passed between layers) only on Blackwell (B200, GB10). On Hopper, vLLM falls back to W4A16: 4-bit weights, 16-bit activations.

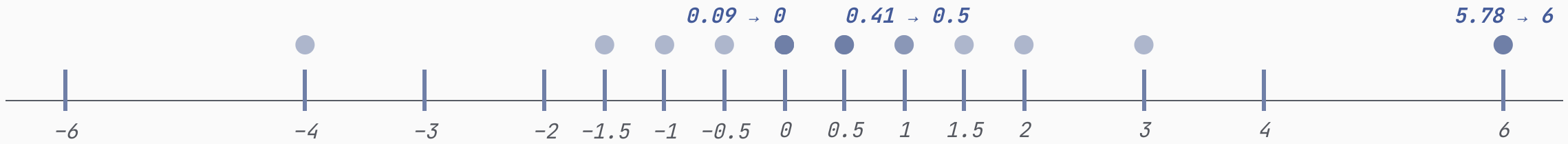
```
BLACKWELL  vllm serve nvidia/Qwen3.8-27B-NVFP4
HOPPER     vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --quantization fp8_per_tensor
CHECK      log "Model loading took X GiB"; a Marlin warning means no 4-bit math
```

Belt schematic. Sizes: Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B, -FP8, nvidia/Qwen3.8-27B-NVFP4 (NVFP4 feed-forward blocks and lm_head; FP8 attention and DeltaNet). NVFP4: 4-bit values, an 8-bit scale per 16 weights, an FP32 scale per tensor. B200 8 TB/s: NVIDIA spec. vLLM 0.31.0: plain --quantization fp8 no longer quantizes a bf16 checkpoint at load.

NVFP4 stores 4-bit values with two levels of scale.

÷ 0.8125 4.70 ÷ 6 = 0.78, rounded to the nearest 8-bit float: 0.8125. One scale per 16 weights puts the largest near 6.

1	0	3	0.5	-1.5	0	6	-1	0	2	-4	0.5	0	1	-0.5	1.5



THE VALUES NVFP4 CAN HOLD

FP32 (32-bit float) tensor scale



BLOCKS OF 16, ONE 8-BIT SCALE EACH

Including scales, each weight uses under a third of bf16 storage.

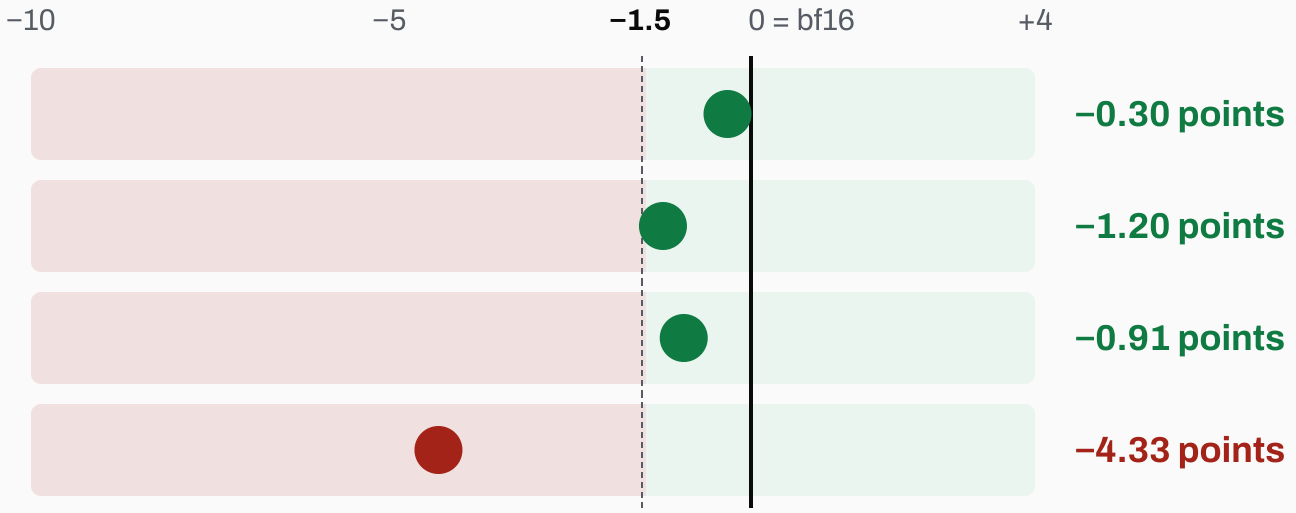
4-bit values plus an 8-bit scale per 16 weights: 4.5 bits per weight.

NVIDIA, "Introducing NVFP4" (Jun 2025) · Four Over Six, arXiv:2512.02010. Example block computed by hand, round to nearest; block scale rounded to FP8 (E4M3).

NVFP4 vs bf16: published score changes.

Example budget: **at most 1.5 points loss**. Within budget / over budget.

Dots are published means; paired uncertainty intervals are unavailable.



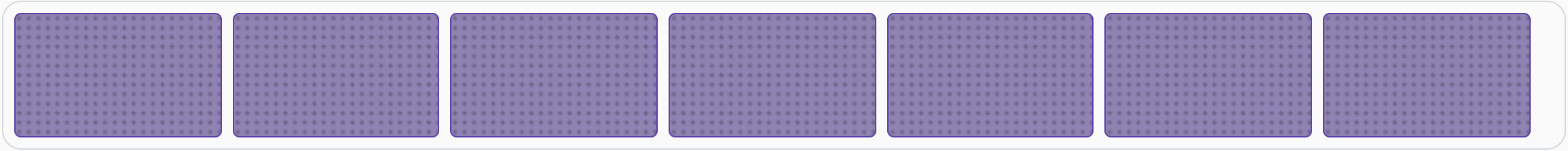
Different quantized layers. Gate on your workload, not on one exam.

```
TRY     lm-eval run --model local-chat-completions --apply_chat_template \
          --model_args model=Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B,base_url=http://localhost:8000/v1/chat/completions \
          --tasks mmlu_pro --num_fewshot 0 --seed 1234 --log_samples --output_path results/baseline
CHECK   repeat both; pair cases/seeds; keep quality loss within your predeclared budget (slide 36)
```

RedHatAI model cards, evaluated on vLLM: Qwen3.8-Flash-Next-NVFP4 (1 seed, expert linears W4A4); gemma-4-31B-it-NVFP4 (3-seed means, block linears W4A4, lm-eval 0.4.11, zero-shot). No paired uncertainty interval is available here.

FP8 KV first. More conversations fit.

IDEAL PAYLOAD BUDGET AFTER WEIGHTS AND RUNTIME: ≈ 29.4 GiB ON THE SPARK



CONVERSATIONS · IDEAL PAYLOAD ESTIMATE **7** 128k context

FP8 · roughly half the payload

```
TRY    vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --kv-cache-dtype fp8
CHECK  startup log "GPU KV cache size: N tokens", before and after
```

DGX Spark, Qwen3.8-27B at 128k; ≈ 29.4 GiB payload budget (slide 11): 8.1 GiB per bf16 conversation, 4.1 GiB in FP8, including unchanged 147 MiB state. Estimates, not measured admissions; startup allocation also includes state copies and padding.

FP8 KV halves the bytes. It only shows when those bytes were the bottleneck.



vLLM's published burst test · Llama-3.3-70B · 4× H100 · P99 (99th percentile) TTFT

17 s bf16 KV **1.3 s** FP8 KV

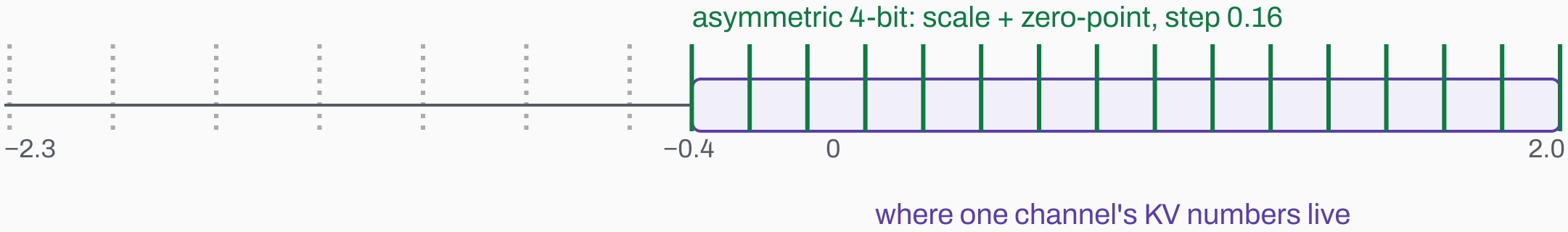
Qwen3-30B-A3B-Instruct-2507 · MoE · 2× H100 · memory to spare

same throughput, FP8 KV vs bf16 KV

No calibrated KV scales in the checkpoint: vLLM uses a default scale and logs a warning.

vLLM blog, 22 Apr 2026 (crossover, gpt-oss-20b, v0.19.1, concurrency 1; full FP8 crosses at 22,109 on H100, ≈ 13k on B200) and 11 May 2026 (Llama burst TTFT, 300 prompts, 1,024 in / 512 out; Qwen throughput across request rates; v0.20.2). Curve shape schematic. Default scale: vLLM 0.31.0 kv_cache.py.

Cached values can cluster away from zero. Put the quantization levels where the values are.



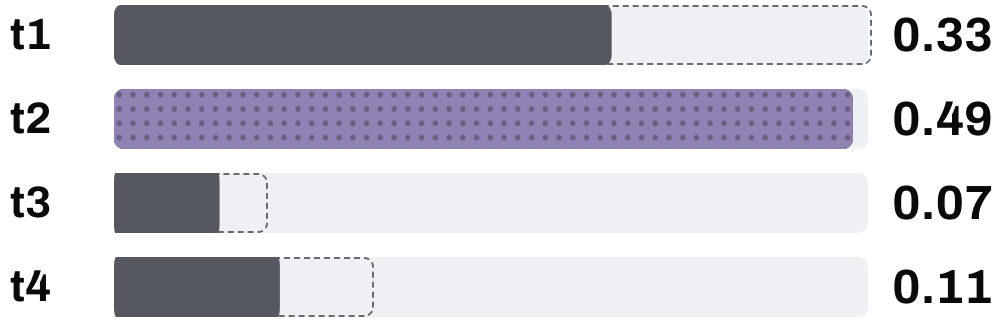
CODES THAT LAND IN RANGE **16 / 16**

At 2 bits there are only 4 codes. Wasting half leaves 2 usable codes.
vLLM's FP8 KV stays symmetric: 8 bits have codes to spare.

Worked example, one channel in [−0.4, 2.0]. Symmetric: scale = 2.0 ÷ 7, codes −8…7. Asymmetric: scale = 2.4 ÷ 15, zero-point shifts the grid. KIVI, arXiv:2402.02750. vLLM 0.31.0 FP8 KV is symmetric only (compressed_tensors.py:1095).

A key error changes who gets attention. A value error changes the mix.

ERROR IN K → CHANGES ATTENTION SHARES



t2's score 1.2 → 2.4: the winner flips

SAME ERROR IN V → AVERAGED BY THE ATTENTION SHARES

ATTENTION SHARES, UNCHANGED



shifts by 0.23 × the error: a change in the mix, not always harmless

4-BIT KEYS + 2-BIT VALUES

10.1

2-BIT KEYS + 4-BIT VALUES

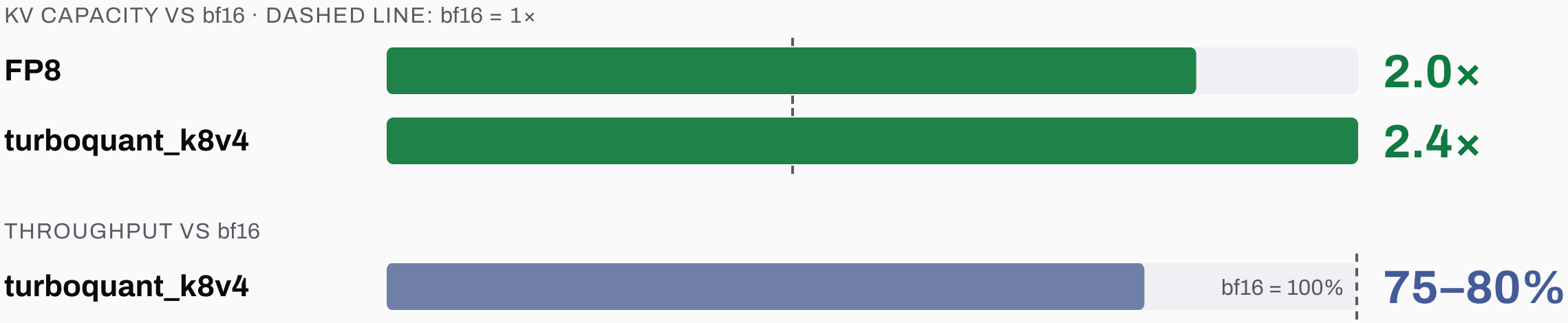
31.5

KVTuner · Table 2

Both average **3 bits per number**.
Reference (8-bit keys, 8-bit values): 9.95.
Perplexity: lower is better. **Give more bits to K here.**

KVTuner: Sensitivity-Aware Layer-wise Mixed Precision KV Cache Quantization for Efficient and Nearly Lossless LLM Inference. arXiv:2502.04420, Table 2: Llama3-8B-Instruct, Wikitext, Transformers KIVI-HQQ. Attention shares are illustrative: softmax over [2.0, 1.2, 0.4, 0.9]. Mechanism: QAQ, arXiv:2403.04643, §3.1.

TurboQuant k8v4 uses 8-bit keys and 4-bit values.

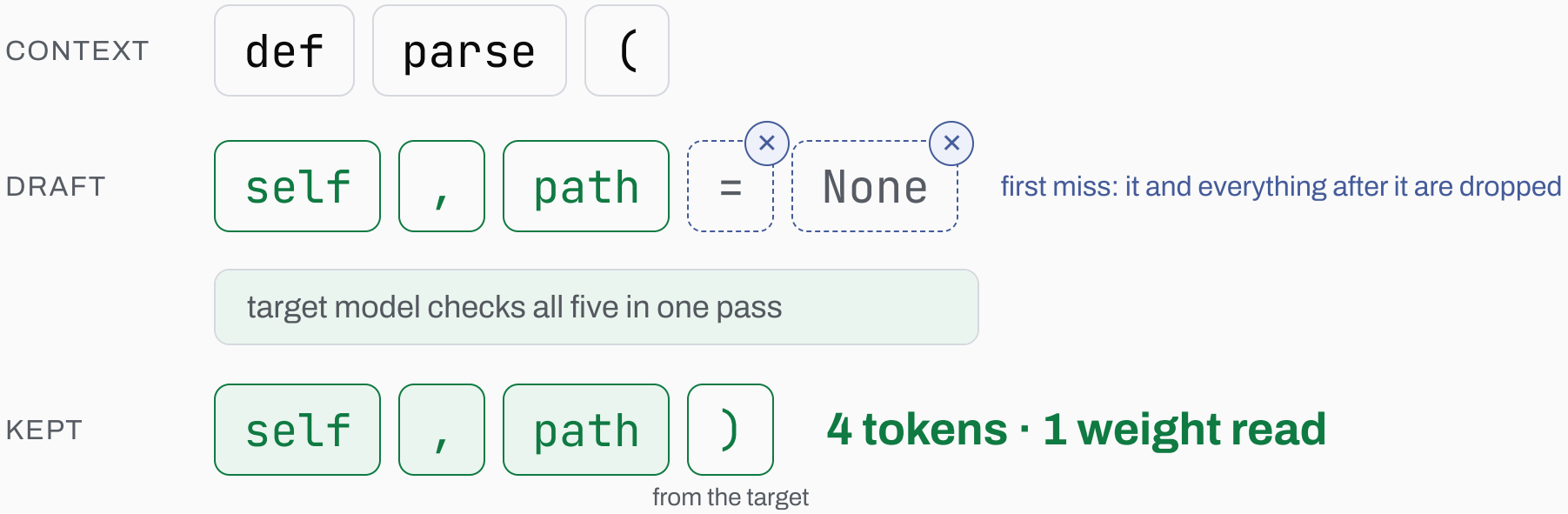


Start with FP8. Reach for k8v4 only when FP8's room isn't enough, and **time it on your GPU** first.

```
TRY    vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B --kv-cache-dtype turboquant_k8v4
CHECK  startup log "GPU KV cache size: N tokens", Mean TPOT and P95 TTFT, all vs fp8
```

vLLM blog, 11 May 2026, v0.20.2, offline, 200 prompts: k8v4 throughput 80% of bf16 (Qwen3-30B-A3B, 2×H100) and 75% (Llama-3.3-70B, 4×H100); 2.4× measured capacity; "no significant advantage over FP8". FP8 2.0×: 16 ÷ 8 bits per KV value.

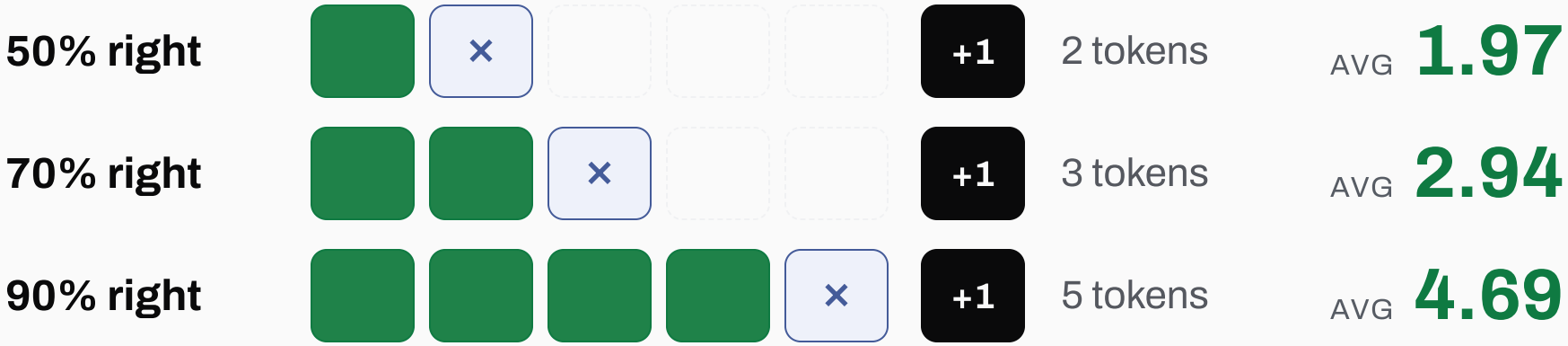
Draft cheap. Verify once. Keep what matches.



Greedy illustration; sampled decoding preserves the target distribution in theory; finite-precision numerics can differ (vLLM 0.31.0 lossless guarantees). Leviathan et al., arXiv:2211.17192: 2×–3× on T5-XXL, batch 1.

Tokens per pass depend on acceptance.

Draft 5 tokens. Each is right with some chance. Keep them until the first miss, then the target adds one of its own.



About 2, 3, 4.7 tokens per pass. vLLM logs this number as `Mean acceptance length`. **Read it on your own traffic.**

More accepted tokens can still be slower. Compare Mean TPOT with speculation off and on; repeat both.

Leviathan et al., arXiv:2211.17192, eq. 1: tokens per pass = $(1 - \alpha^{\gamma+1}) \div (1 - \alpha)$, α = chance a guess is kept, γ = guesses drafted. Here $\gamma = 5$, so 1.97, 2.94, 4.69, if each guess is independent and equally likely to be kept.

Match the drafter to your traffic.

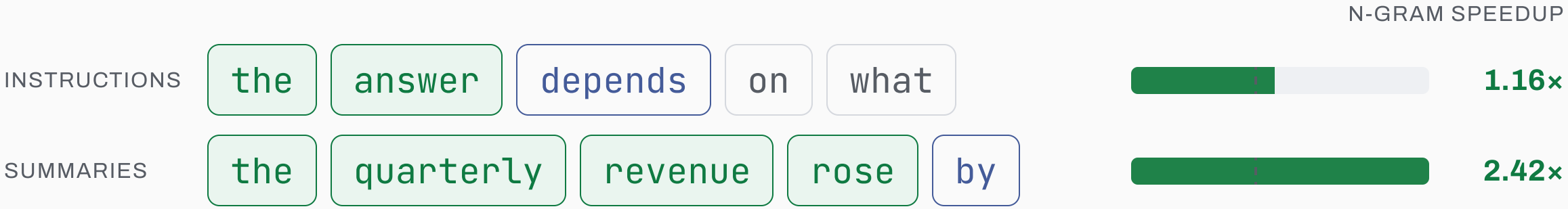
Trained draft heads

EAGLE-3, DSpark or the model's own draft layers (MTP, multi-token prediction). A published Qwen3.8-27B DSpark speculator: **3.76** output tokens per pass, including the target token, on tool calls. **Acceptance only; speedup not measured.**

N-gram lookup

Match the latest tokens to an earlier prompt sequence; propose what followed. No training.

Never use a draft model as slow as the target.



MTP · START AT 1
```
vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B \
  -sc '{"method":"mtp","num_speculative_tokens":1}'
```

N-GRAM
```
vllm serve Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B \
  -sc '{"method":"ngram","num_speculative_tokens":3,"prompt_lookup_min":2,"prompt_lookup_max":4}'
```

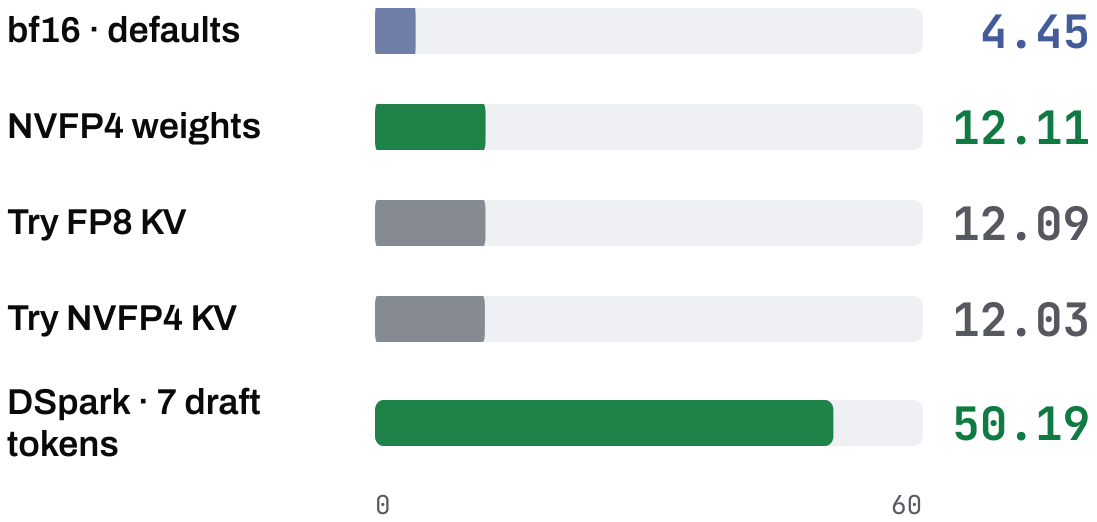
CHECK
```
log "SpecDecoding metrics: Mean acceptance length" and Mean TPOT
```

Token rows illustrative. n-gram (prompt lookup, Vicuna-13B): Alpaca 1.16×, CNN/DailyMail 2.42× (arXiv:2503.01840, Table 1). RedHatAI/Qwen3.8-27B-speculator.dspark, vLLM 0.29.0, acceptance length including the target token: tool calls 3.76, writing 3.77, math 5.74.

Practical experiment: tune one vLLM deployment.

1. Diagnose, then tune

OUTPUT tok/s · 1 CLIENT · 128 OUTPUT TOKENS



Per decode step: **≈9.4 MB of attention KV** vs ≈17.6 GB of weights.
Smaller KV adds room; short decode stays flat.

2. Coding agent spawning subagents

RECORDED REPLAY · MEDIAN 79k IN / 267 OUT

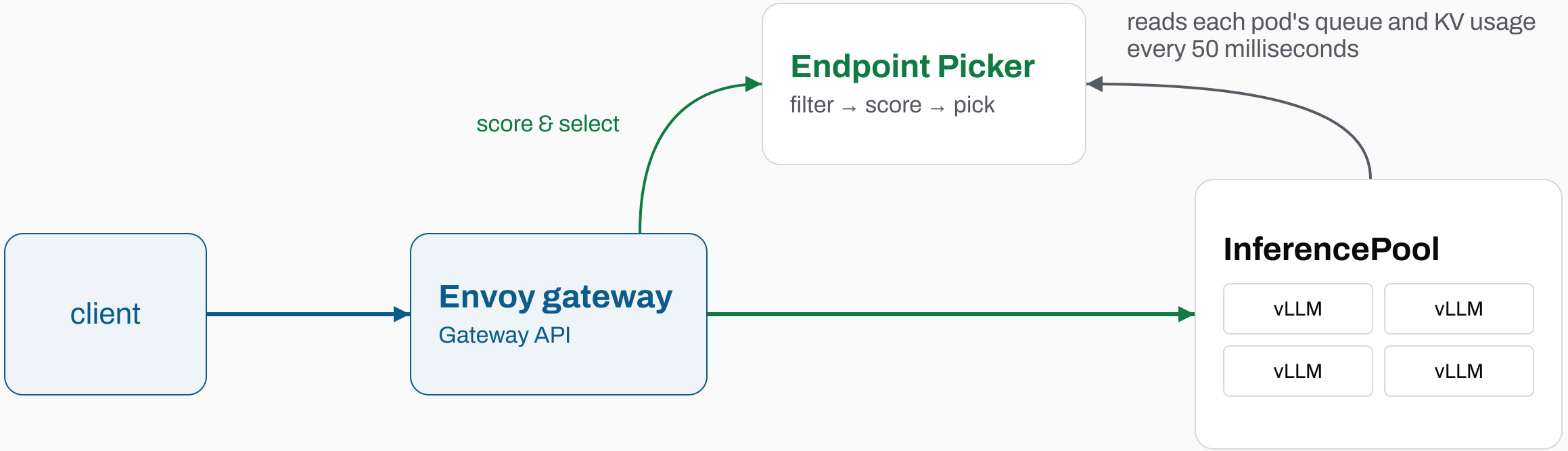
Total output tok/s · below: P95 first-token wait

KV · 64 GiB each	4 in flight	8 in flight	16 in flight
bf16 (default)	**73.71** 8.62 s	**89.08** 8.74 s	**87.51** 29.54 s
FP8	**67.54** 10.27 s	**77.57** 19.66 s	**76.12** 55.50 s
NVFP4	**47.59** 17.94 s	**52.11** 43.67 s	**52.07** 105.65 s

More token capacity did not mean more throughput.
64 GiB per format; same 8 GiB memory guard.

Qwen3.8-27B · GB10 · vLLM 0.32.0 · 25–27 Oct 2026. Right: NVFP4 weights, native MTP7; FP4 kernel autotuning off. Medians: 3 × 16 requests; 2 × Spark1 + Spark2; primers excluded. 4-in-flight run before restart; thermal/order effects possible. Don't multiply gains across workloads. Experiment methods: handout.

A prefix-aware router knows which prefix each pod has cached.



Precise routing: KV block events → index of block locations; match the request's prefix.

Schematic; example pinned to llm-d v0.10 (29 Sep 2026), CNCF Sandbox; Gateway API Inference Extension v1. Poll: --refresh-metrics-interval, default 50 ms; queue and KV usage are load, not prefix identity. Same pattern: NVIDIA Dynamo (--router-mode kv), vLLM Production Stack.

Random routing repeats each shared prefix's prefill across pods.

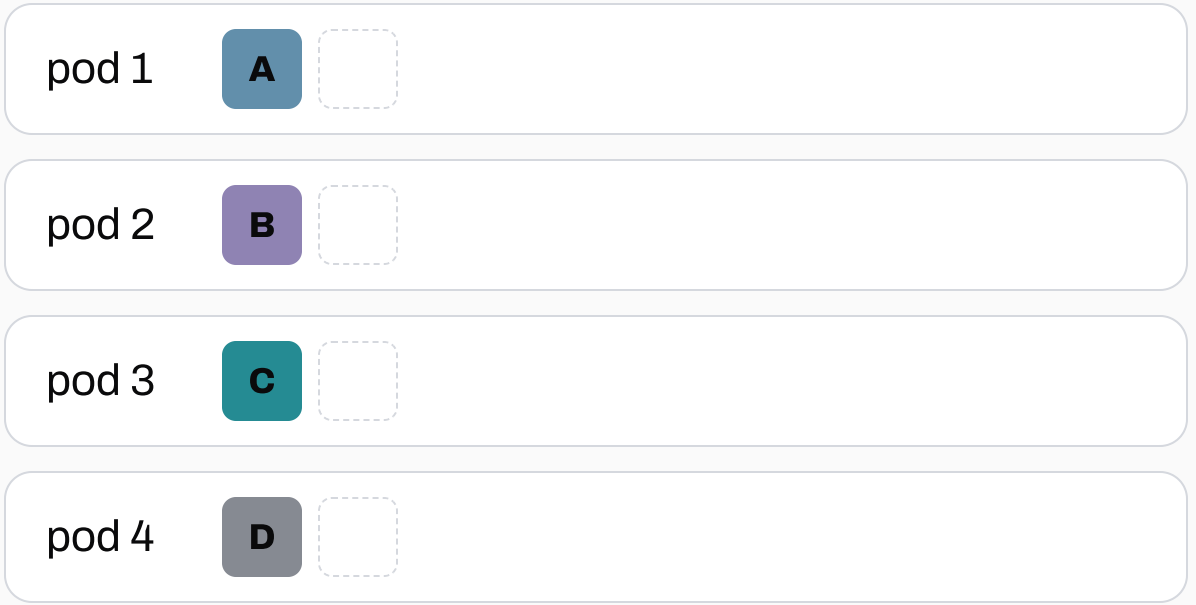
PREFIX-AWARE ROUTING: EACH PREFIX STICKS TO ITS WARM POD

llm-d BENCHMARK · TTFT P90 (90th PERCENTILE)

92.6 s → 0.54 s

OUTPUT tok/s

4,429 → 8,730

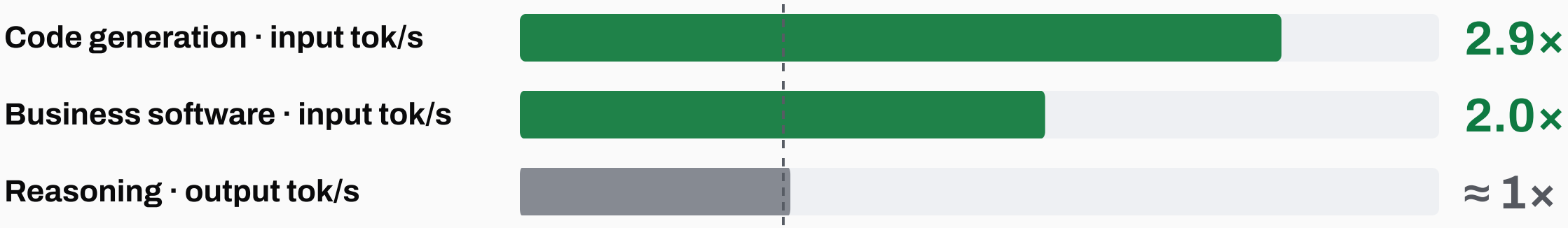


TRY `precise-prefix-cache-routing · helm chart llm-d-router-standalone v0.11.0`
CHECK `prefix token hit rate per pod, before and after`

llm-d blog, 24 Sep 2025: 8 vLLM pods × 2 H100, 32B Qwen, 150 tenants × 6,000-token shared prefix. Random vs precise prefix-aware routing.

Routing saves prefill. It can't shrink decode.

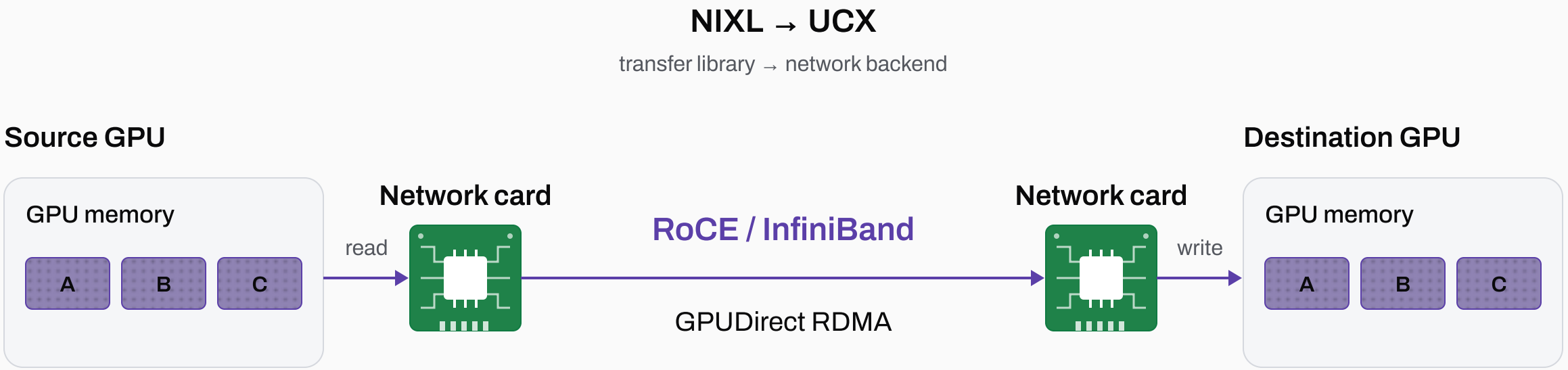
llm-d's default router vs Kubernetes round-robin, same replica count per test. Dashed line: round-robin, 1×.



Reasoning averages about 8,000 output tokens per request. No router shrinks that read.

llm-d blog, 17 Aug 2026. Throughput at the knee. Qwen3-32B, TP=2 (tensor parallel: each layer split across two H100s). Matched pods within each comparison: ten for code and reasoning, eight for business software. Code-gen: about 70,000-token prompts, 46k vs 16k input tok/s; business software 90k vs 45k. Reasoning 7.0k vs 6.8k output tok/s, about 8,000 output tokens on average.

Move cached KV directly between GPUs.



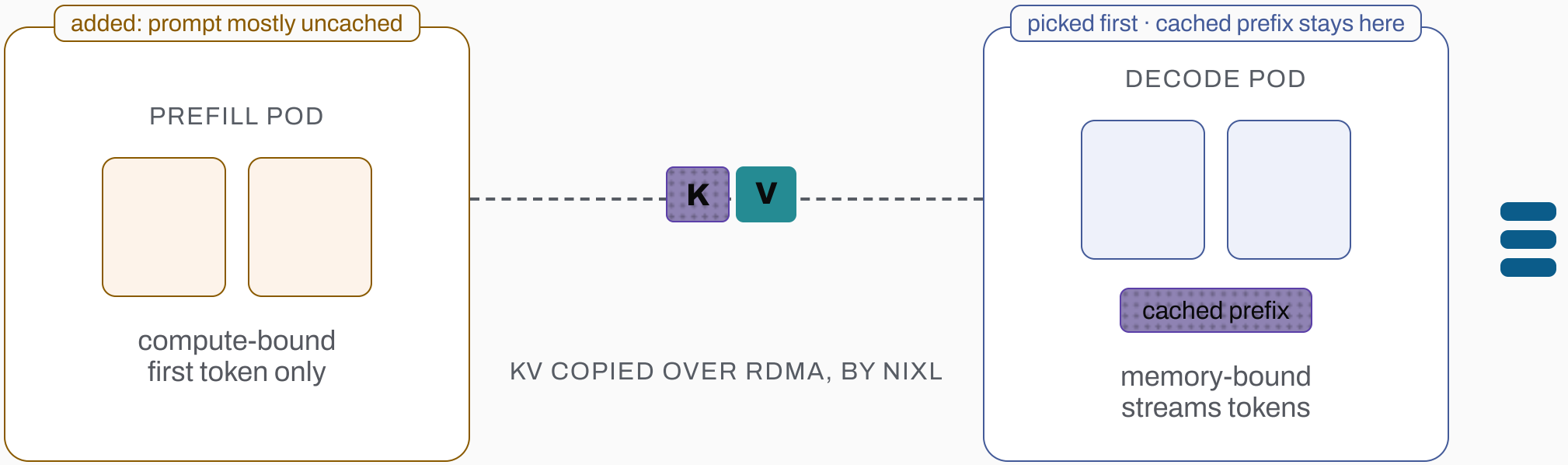
RDMA: remote direct memory access

RoCE: RDMA over Converged Ethernet

The KV payload does not stage in system RAM.

Schematic GPUDirect RDMA path: compatible registered GPU buffers and connector coordination required. llm-d P/D uses NIXL; UCX is the default backend for on-prem RoCE/InfiniBand. This transfer mechanism does not provide automatic prefix discovery.

Disaggregated P/D: prefill pods, decode pods.



The picker chooses the decode pod first, and adds a prefill pod **only when much of the prompt is uncached**.

Schematic. llm-d prefill/decode (P/D) docs: suited to about 10k in / 1k out, not 200 in / 200 out. Standard-network fallback is for testing only. Splitwise arXiv:2311.18677 · DistServe arXiv:2401.09670.

Alert on latency, cache pressure and queues.

< 500 ms

example · time to first token (TTFT) P95,
interactive; set it and per-request TPOT
P95 from your SLO (service-level objective)

Cache hits

live · prefix token hit rate, by pod and workload

MBU

before and after a change
one-user MBU per model and GPU

$ / 1M

before and after a change
GPU $/hour ÷ output tokens/hour × 1M

busy GPU 100%



queue: 2 waiting

overloaded GPU 100%



queue keeps growing

Scale on active requests and queues, not GPU utilization. **Alert on** KV usage, queue depth, P95 TTFT and per-request TPOT.

500 ms is an illustrative latency target. Set targets from your SLO. Hit rate counts tokens; there is no universal target. Scrape /metrics: vllm:kv_cache_usage_perc and vllm:num_requests_waiting. Busy vs overloaded schematic; llm-d router queues need flow control.

The eval recipe: change one thing, repeat both setups.

1 Freeze

Save prompts, checks and setup. Set the quality-loss budget. Change **one** thing.

2 Repeat both

Repeat baseline and candidate. Match traffic, warm-up and cache state, including persistent tiers.

3 Compare paired cases

Pair the same cases and seeds. Score the exam and your task separately, with uncertainty intervals.

4 Verdict

- **keep** repeatable gain **and** quality within budget
  e.g. −0.6 to +0.2 against −1
- **revert** no repeatable gain
- **revert** quality loss clearly exceeds budget
- **hold** uncertain: keep baseline, gather evidence

Measure first. Then pull the levers your traffic needs.

For decode. Estimate the ceiling, then one-user MBU.	Short context, speculation off. Low MBU: profile overhead. Batch within the latency target. GuideLLM, a vLLM subproject, runs load sweeps and reports latency and throughput.
Repeated prefixes	Prefix cache (on by default). Then route to it.
Weights dominate	FP8 where the GPU has FP8 math (an FP8 checkpoint, or `--quantization fp8_per_tensor`); NVFP4 where it has FP4 math (Blackwell).
Context dominates	`--kv-cache-dtype fp8`. Then fewer bits, carefully.
Predictable output	Speculative decode: `mtp`, `eagle3`, `dspark` or `ngram`.
Long prompts, strict TTFT	`--max-num-batched-tokens` first. A prefill/decode split needs RDMA.
Keep only repeatable gains after the quality gate passes.	High MBU, batching plateaued, nothing above applies: stop. No sampler, CUDA graph or sequence-limit tweak shrinks the read.

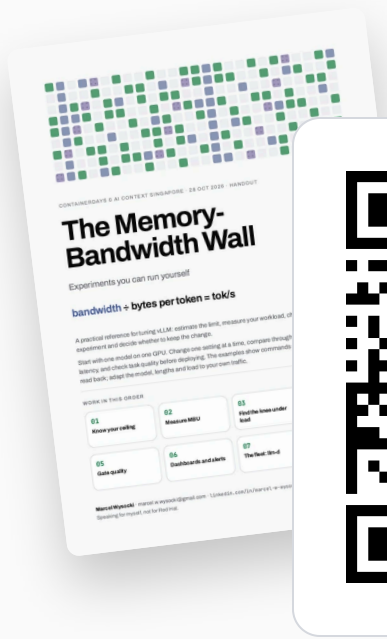
vLLM 0.31.0 commands and pinned tool versions: field guide. GuideLLM: github.com/vllm-project/guidellm.

Your GPU isn't slow. It's starving.

Skip repeated work.
Min the bytes.
Max the tokens per read.

bandwidth ÷ bytes per token = tok/s

Marcel Wysocki · marcel.w.wysocki@gmail.com



Handout

Run the field experiment yourself

Download PDF

Session feedback

The Memory-Bandwidth Wall: A Field Guide to Min-Maxing LLM Serving with vLLM

For this session and the organizers

sfeedback.com/Wj5q8l

Two prices. Same million tokens.

30×

CACHE MISS

$0.66

per 1M input tokens

whole prompt computed

the GPU **computes**

CACHE HIT

$0.022

per 1M input tokens



the GPU **remembers**

DeepSeek V4-Pro API, off-peak · checked 25 Oct 2026 · api-docs.deepseek.com/quick_start/pricing · work strips schematic.

Throughput decides whether the box pays rent.



OUTPUT tok/s ACROSS THE BATCH

1,916

Revenue = output tok/s × 3600 × ($3.48 + 2 × $1.74) per 1M: 2 input tokens per output token, every input token billed at the uncached rate, DeepSeek's former list price. Rental example: Runpod Community Cloud $5.98/GPU-hour; CoreWeave $8.60 (25 Oct 2026).

These flags don't shrink the weight read.

~~**Sampler settings**~~

Change which token is chosen.

~~**CUDA graph tweaks at high MBU**~~

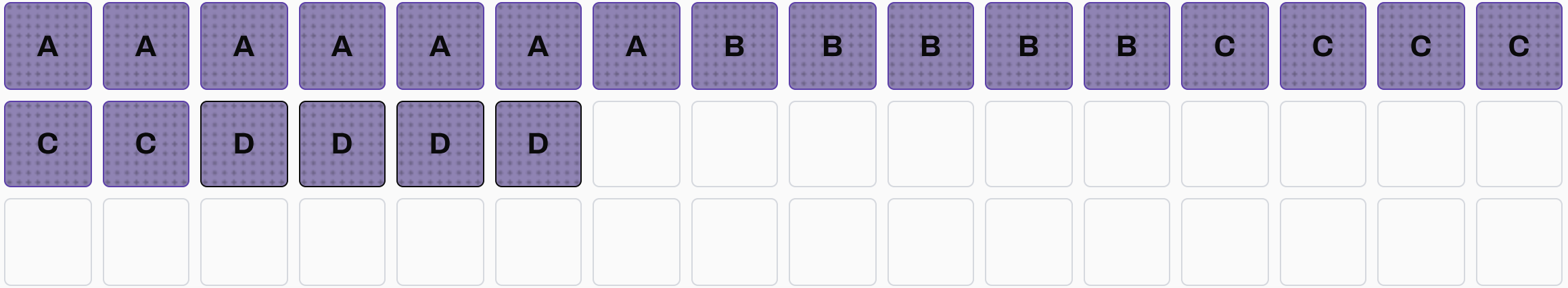
Launch overhead was the low-MBU problem.

~~**More `--max-num-seqs` after throughput plateaus**~~

Extra sequences still need KV room.

Reserve KV up front and most of it sits empty.

BLOCKS OF 16 TOKENS, ALLOCATED AS TOKENS ARRIVE



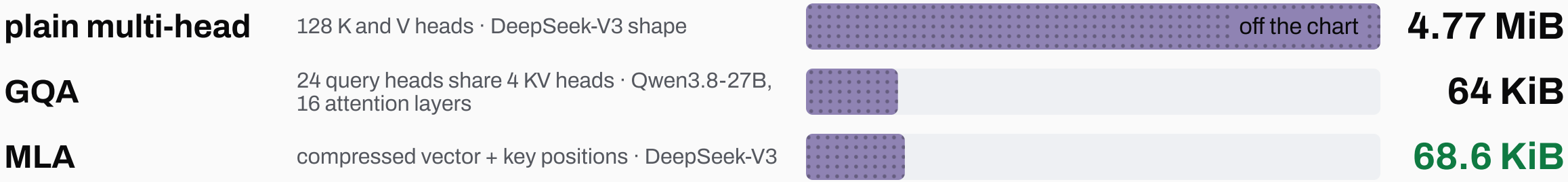
The paper's Orca baselines used 20–38% of KV memory for tokens. vLLM: near-zero waste, 2–4× throughput.

Kwon et al., 2023, arXiv:2309.06180: 20–38% utilization (Fig. 2, Orca variants), 2–4× throughput, OPT and LLaMA on A100s. Layout schematic, 16-token blocks.

DeepSeek V3 caches 71× less than plain attention would.

Same idea, fewer bytes: **share** K and V across query heads, or **compress** them into one small vector and rebuild them when needed.

KV BYTES PER TOKEN · AXIS ZOOMED ABOUT 13×: 0 TO 400 KIB



DEEPSEEK'S FP8 CACHE, ONE LAYER: 656 B (512 FP8 + 16 SCALES + 128 ROPE) INSTEAD OF 1,152 B



DeepSeek-V3 config: kv_lora_rank 512, qk_rope_head_dim 64, 61 layers; plain multi-head = 128 × (192 + 128) × 2 B × 61. Qwen3.8-27B config: 16 × 4 KV heads × 256 × 2 × 2 B = 64 KiB; 146.8 MiB fixed DeltaNet state extra. vLLM 0.31.0 fp8_ds_mla layout (V3.2).

DeepSeek V4 compresses the sequence, not just the vector.

tokens



CSA · 4 → 1



a learned summary of every 4 tokens

indexer

V4-Pro: a small scorer picks **1,024 entries** for main attention. Flash uses 512. The indexer still reads.

HCA · 128 → 1

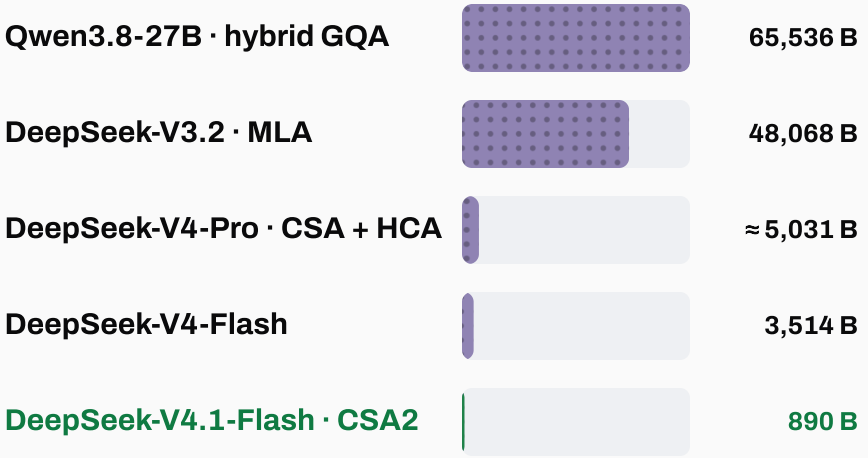


every other layer: a coarse map of everything, read in full

recent

the **last 128 tokens stay uncompressed**: a query can't see its own unfinished block, so recent tokens stay whole

GLOBAL KV BYTES PER TOKEN. EXCLUDES FIXED WINDOW AND STATE. MIXED PRECISION.

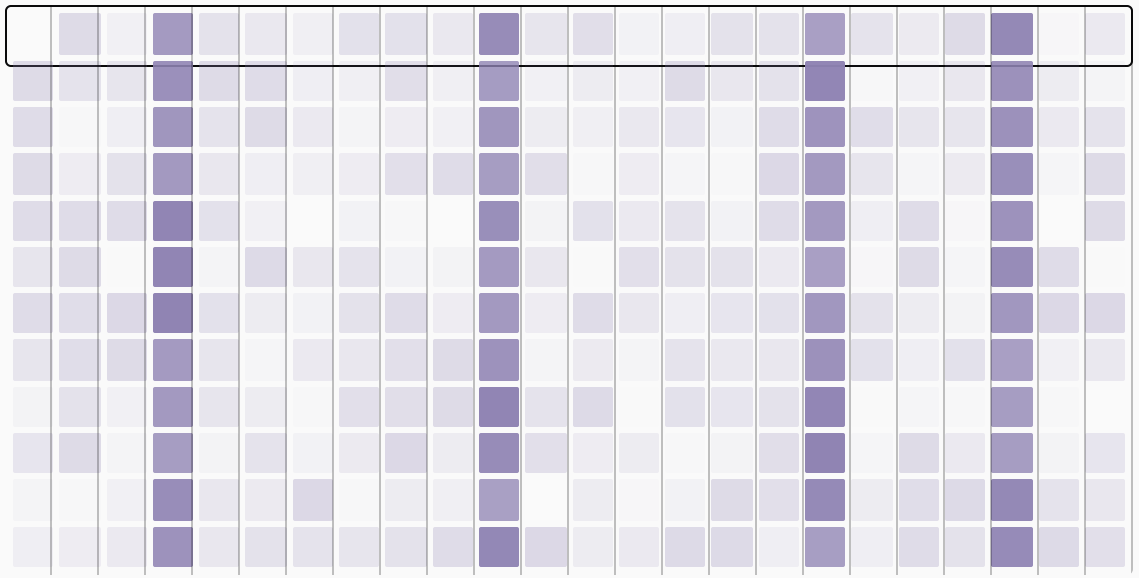


CSA2: layers share entries and picks, no HCA, FP4 cache. 74× less than Qwen3.8-27B's growing KV.

Token rows schematic. DeepSeek-V4 report, arXiv:2606.19348 · V4.1-Flash report, Fig. 1b. V4-Pro computed from config (MXFP4 indexer; FP8: about 5,511 B). Qwen3.8-27B bf16: 16 full-attention layers; fixed DeltaNet state excluded.

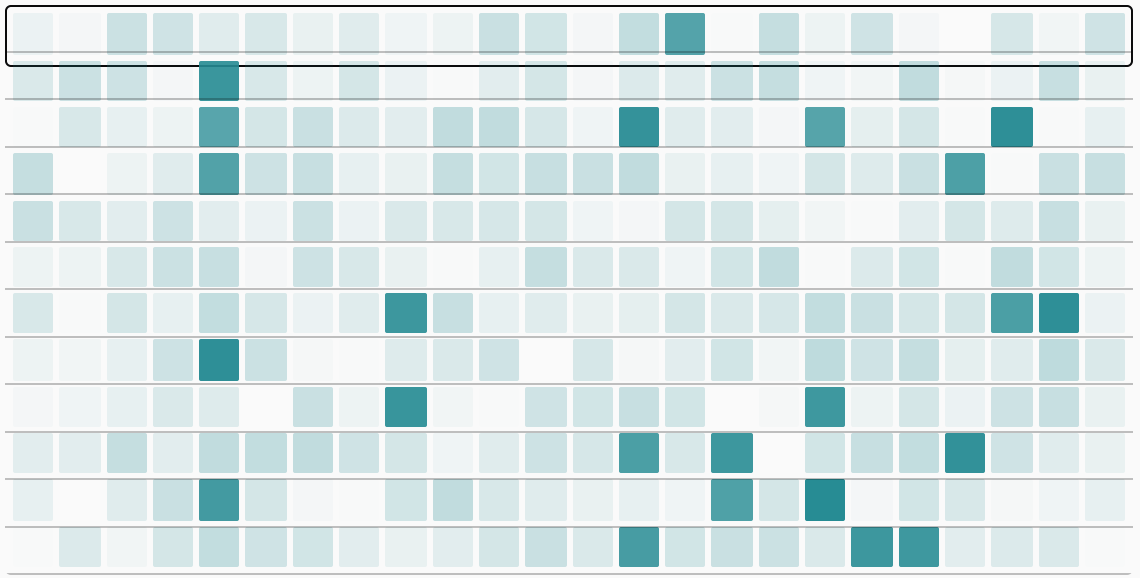
K and V are not the same tensor.

KEYS · OUTLIERS BY CHANNEL



quantize **per channel** ↓

VALUES · OUTLIERS BY TOKEN



quantize **per token** →

Keep the first token wide. At 2-bit nonuniform, without sparse outliers: perplexity 23.3 without it, 9.6 with it. 16-bit: 4.6.

KIVI, arXiv:2402.02750 · KVQuant, arXiv:2401.18079, Table 13 (Llama-2-13B, Wikitext-2): with 1% sparse outliers, keeping the first token wide changes perplexity from about 4.85 to 4.78. Heatmaps are schematic.

vLLM serves the request. llm-d routes across pods.

API + scheduler
continuous batching, chunked prefill

PROBLEM 3

Prefix cache
reuse KV for repeated prefixes

LEVER 1

PagedAttention
KV in blocks, near-zero waste

ENGINE CORE

KV quantization
FP8, TurboQuant

LEVER 3

Kernels
FlashAttention, FP8, NVFP4

LEVER 2

Spec decode
draft, verify, keep

LEVER 4

TP / PP / EP
tensor, pipeline, expert parallel: one model, many GPUs

SCALE

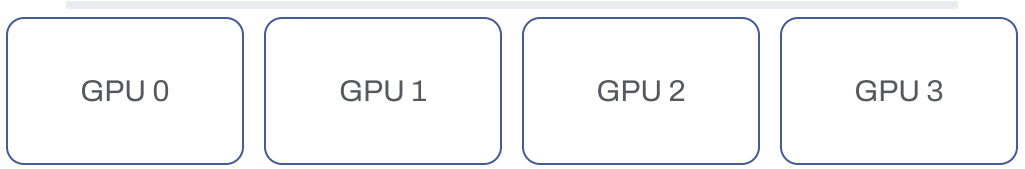
llm-d
routing and prefill/decode (P/D) across pods

SCALE

Schematic. PagedAttention waste: Kwon et al., arXiv:2309.06180.

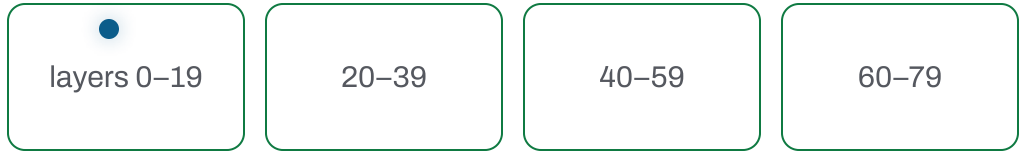
TP splits a layer. PP splits the model.

Tensor parallel (TP)



Every layer, all GPUs, in lockstep. All-reduce, an exchange and sum of partial results, on every layer.
Wants NVLink. Inside the node.

Pipeline parallel (PP)



Layer ranges in turn. Activations, the intermediate values, hop once per stage.
Less communication. Measure across nodes.

Schematic. All-reduce exchanges and sums each GPU's partial results.

Start with the baseline. Add recipes for your workload.

Optimized baseline

Envoy + Endpoint Picker + vLLM pods

start here · any fleet

Tiered prefix cache

HBM → CPU memory → storage

big shared prefixes

P/D disaggregation

prefill pods → KV over NIXL
(GPU-to-GPU transfer) → decode pods

long prompts, strict TTFT, RDMA

Wide expert parallel

16 prefill + 16 decode B200:
≈ 3.1k output tok/s per decode GPU

DeepSeek-class MoE · batch processing, relaxed latency

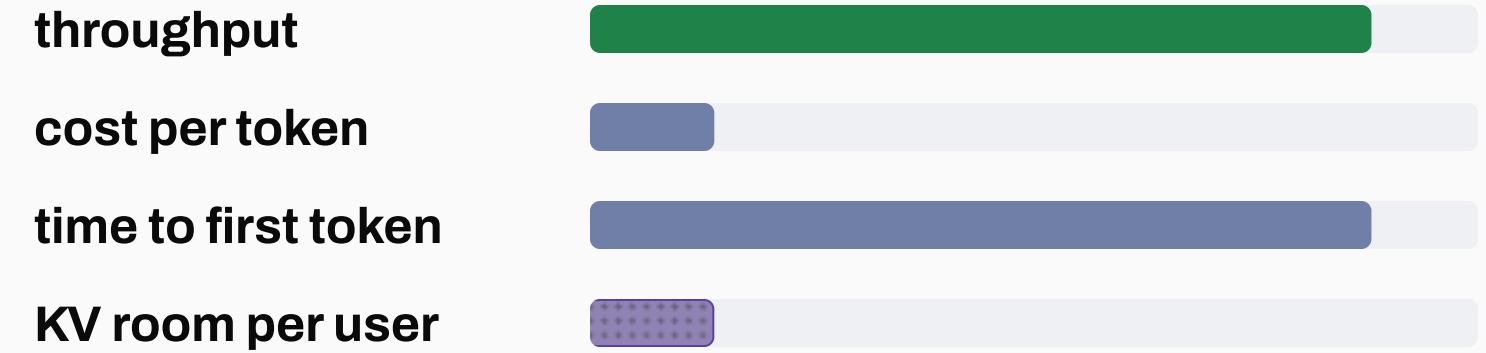
Scale on active requests and queues, not GPU utilization: busy and overloaded look the same.

llm-d "well-lit path" guides. Wide-EP: llm-d v0.5 blog, random 1k/1k. Autoscaling: KEDA on Endpoint Picker metrics.

Bigger batches trade latency and KV room for throughput.

BATCH SIZE

1 many

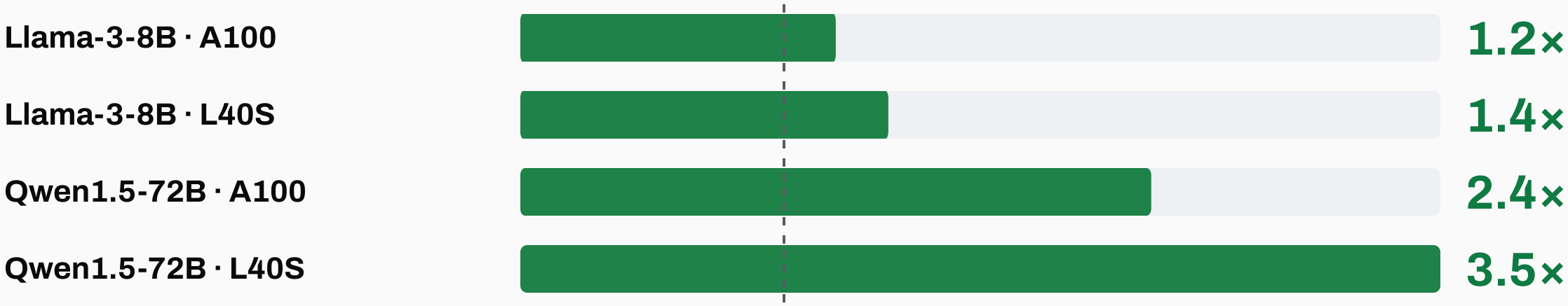


Four numbers move together. **Change one variable at a time.**

Schematic. Directions, not measurements.

QServe improved the whole serving system.

Existing 4-bit integer methods paid 20–90% runtime overhead for dequantization in large-batch serving. QServe's system gains. Dashed line: TensorRT-LLM baseline, 1×.



Lin et al., arXiv:2405.04532: maximum throughput, 1,024 in / 512 out, same memory per device, against the best TensorRT-LLM v0.9.0 configuration (FP16, W8A8 or W4A16). Whole-system comparison.

Report cache-hit rate alongside input throughput.

DEEPSEEK V3/R1 · INPUT THROUGHPUT PER EIGHT-H800 NODE



73.7k tok/s

A hit still costs find the block · read it · move it to the right GPU · compute the tail

Ask every vendor for the hit rate behind that number.

DeepSeek Open Infra Index, Day 6 (Feb 2025), 24-hour averages per eight-H800 node: 73.7k input tok/s in prefill or 14.8k output tok/s in decode; 56.3% of input tokens hit the on-disk KV cache.